In the meantime, the earliest writings that can be dated with absolute confidence remain Ashoka's proclamations, inscribed initially on rock faces and large boulders and later on sandstone pillars.

Ashoka Maurya's thirty-seven-year rule over more territory than any other ruler before or since is one of the most remarkable episodes in India's long history. I have written elsewhere about Ashoka's achievements[3] so allow me to restrict myself here to his impact south of the Narmada.

Ashoka had to fight for several years before wresting his father's throne from his elder half-brothers, but by about 269 BCE he was fully in control of his empire in the North, whereupon he embarked on the violent subjugation of the as yet unconquered kingdom of Kalinga, modern Odisha. This was achieved at such cost that it may well have been the catalyst that converted Ashoka from a nominal supporter of Buddhism into a genuine and remorseful convert. Some two and a half years later Ashoka began an extended tour of his empire. We can plot at least part of the ground he covered from the earliest of his four main sets of written proclamations, which have come to be known as his Minor Rock Edicts (MREs), inscribed in what is known as Ashokan Brahmi script.

These MREs mark the first public appearance of a written language, initially inscribed on boulders, and later on pillars, plaques and copper plates. Ashoka's rule also sees the first sculptures carved out of rock, and the first excavating into rock to make cells for ascetics – new techniques made possible by advances in iron-working that produced harder steel.[4] Of these three innovations the one that had the most far-reaching impact was Ashoka's use of the new Brahmi script to make his pronouncements known in the furthest corners of his empire. What is also striking is that the language Ashoka chose for these pronouncements was not